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THA 215: Basic Film Analysis and Appreciation - Reading the Moving Image

From shot to sequence: how films mean what they mean

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

Film analysis is close reading with a stopwatch. This pack teaches you to break a sequence into shots, analyse framing, movement, editing, sound and performance, and write an analysis that cites timecodes as evidence. It includes Nollywood and African cinema examples rather than a Hollywood-only canon.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Break a sequence into shots and describe each accurately.
- Analyse framing, camera movement, lighting and colour.
- Explain continuity, montage and editing rhythm.
- Write a timecode-based analysis of a short sequence.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Mise-en-scene and cinematography

Everything in the frame is a decision.

- Mise-en-scene: setting, props, costume, performance and lighting within the frame.
- Framing: shot size, angle, headroom, composition and depth.
- Movement: pan, tilt, dolly, handheld and crane each carry a different feel.
- Lens and focus: wide lenses exaggerate space; long lenses compress it.
- Lighting: direction, contrast and colour temperature shape mood and meaning.
- Production design communicates period, class and character before dialogue begins.

Editing and sound

The cut is the basic unit of film grammar.

- Continuity editing preserves spatial and temporal logic for the viewer.
- Montage creates meaning through juxtaposition rather than continuity.
- Cutting rhythm controls pace and emotional pressure.
- Sound design: dialogue, ambience, effects and music; diegetic versus non-diegetic.
- Silence is a designed choice, not an absence.
- Sound bridges link scenes and smooth transitions.

> **Cite timecodes**
> '01:12:30 to 01:14:05' is evidence. 'The scene where she cries' is not. Timestamps make your argument checkable.

Writing the analysis

Structure beats adjectives.

1. State your claim about how the sequence produces meaning.
2. Describe the sequence's duration and position in the film.
3. Analyse two or three formal elements in detail.
4. Quote dialogue exactly and give timecodes.
5. Connect form to theme, genre or context.
6. Avoid plot summary except where it is necessary to your argument.

The sequence is the unit of meaning

A single shot can be beautiful and mean very little. Meaning appears when shots are placed next to each other, because the cut creates a relationship the audience completes. Two neutral images in sequence produce a third idea: a face, then a plate of food, reads as hunger or refusal depending on the performance in the first shot.

This is why film analysis should begin with the sequence rather than the frame. Identify where a sequence starts and ends (usually by a change of place, time or argument), then ask what question the sequence poses and how the editing answers it. A chase sequence poses "will they escape?" and answers it with rhythm: shots shorten as pressure rises.

Mise-en-scene - everything within the frame - is the other half. Setting, costume, lighting, colour, the arrangement of bodies and the choice of what is left out all communicate before a character speaks. Learn to describe a frame neutrally first ("she sits at the far end of a long table, lit from one side, the other chair empty"), then interpret. Description first protects you from inventing.

Editing, time and point of view

Continuity editing is a set of conventions designed to be invisible: shot-reverse-shot, eyeline matches, match cuts on action, and the 180-degree rule. Its purpose is to let the audience follow space and time without effort. When a film breaks those rules, it is usually asking you to notice.

Alternatives are deliberate. A jump cut compresses time and signals impatience or fracture. A long take preserves the continuity of real time and refuses to guide your attention, which is why it feels either immersive or anxious depending on the content. Montage builds meaning by association rather than by spatial continuity, and is the standard tool for compressing labour, training or the passage of months.

Point of view is the question of whose experience organises the film. A shot from a character's optical position, a voice-over, a sound that only they can hear, or a restriction of information to what they know all establish subjectivity. Track who is allowed to know what and when; the pattern is usually the film's argument.

> **Sound carries half the meaning**
> Try watching a two-minute sequence with the sound off, then with the image off. The second exercise usually tells you more about how the scene was built.

Writing analysis that earns marks

The standard failure is the review: "the cinematography was stunning and the acting was superb". A review evaluates; analysis explains. Replace every adjective with a mechanism. Not "tense editing" but "the average shot length drops from six seconds to two across the sequence, so the audience has less time to locate each new image".

Cite with precision. Name the sequence by its position and content ("the market sequence, 00:34:10-00:37:20"), and describe what you saw. If you are working from a screening you cannot rewind, take notes in a fixed pattern during the film: shot size, camera movement, sound, and one word for what changed.

Context belongs at the end of the argument, not the beginning. Industrial conditions, censorship, budget and genre expectations explain why a film makes the choices it does, but they cannot substitute for showing the choices. Establish the evidence, then explain it.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 215

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- THA 215 Basic Film Analysis and Appreciation is named in the 2018 course description page
- Film study is grouped with media arts and broadcast production
- THA 333 Jingle and Effects Design and THA 252 production fundamentals are described nearby

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 215 Basic Film Analysis and Appreciation, 3 credits, first semester, 200 level
- Listed with THA 211 and THA 213 in the theory block
- Film studies later expands into THA 324 directing and THA 344 design for screen

What changed: The 2019 listing places film analysis in a theory block, with production following in the media courses.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Film analysis remains the 200-level entry to the film track in the compiled map
- The department name now includes Film Studies, so expect expanded screen examples
- Confirm whether analysis is assessed by exam, coursework or both

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

WORKED EXAMPLES

Do it once, slowly

These are not model answers to copy. They show the reasoning a strong student would use, step by step, so you can repeat the process on a question you have not seen.

1. Analysing a two-minute sequence

You must produce 800 words on one sequence. Here is a repeatable structure.

1. Watch once without notes to establish the dramatic question.
2. Watch again and log every shot: number, size, movement, duration, sound.
3. Identify the pattern: does shot length shorten, does the camera move more, does sound become subjective?
4. Pick three moments where the pattern breaks and describe them precisely.
5. Argue what the pattern does to the audience's knowledge or sympathy.
6. Conclude with what the sequence contributes to the film's overall argument.

> **What to carry forward**
> Log, find the pattern, then interpret the pattern. Never interpret before you have logged.

2. Why a scene feels false

A dialogue scene in a student film feels stagey although the writing is fine. Diagnose it.

1. Check coverage: if every shot is a medium two-shot, the scene has no visual rhythm.
2. Check eyelines: crossing the line makes the conversation spatially incoherent.
3. Check the cutaways: without reaction shots, the audience never sees anyone listen.
4. Check pace: uniform shot lengths remove emphasis, so nothing lands.
5. Check sound: no room tone makes cuts audible, which reads as amateur.
6. Repair by planning one close-up on the turn of the scene and varied shot lengths.

> **What to carry forward**
> Stagey film is usually a coverage problem, not a writing problem.

EXAM TECHNIQUE

Questions with model answers

Written in the shape your course is usually examined, with the marking logic spelled out. Attempt each one under time before you read the outline.

Q1. Using one sequence, show how editing creates meaning rather than simply recording action.

20 marks

1. Define the sequence and its dramatic question.
2. Describe the editing pattern with evidence: shot lengths, transitions, ordering.
3. Show one moment where the cut produces an idea absent from either shot alone.
4. Show one moment where continuity is deliberately broken and explain the effect.
5. Conclude on editing as argument, not transcription.

> **Where marks are lost**
> Listing shot types without saying what the arrangement does to the audience.

Q2. What is mise-en-scene and how does it communicate before dialogue?

15 marks

1. Define the term: everything placed within the frame.
2. Break it into setting, costume, lighting, colour, composition, performance.
3. Give one frame described neutrally then interpreted.
4. Explain the principle: the frame is a set of choices, and absences are choices too.

REFERENCE

Glossary

Use these definitions in your own sentences; a copied definition rarely earns full marks.

Mise-en-scene. Everything arranged within the frame: setting, costume, light, colour, bodies and props.

Sequence. A group of shots forming a unit of action or argument, usually unified by place or time.

Continuity editing. Conventions that make cuts invisible so the audience follows space and time easily.

Jump cut. An abrupt cut between similar framings that compresses time or signals fracture.

Long take. A shot held for an extended period, preserving real time and refusing to guide attention.

Montage. Editing that builds meaning by association and compresses time.

Shot-reverse-shot. Alternating shots of two speakers that constructs a conversation in space.

Match cut. A cut linking two shots through a visual or rhythmic correspondence.

Diegetic. Belonging to the story world, as opposed to added for the audience.

Point of view. The perspective whose knowledge and experience organise the film.

Average shot length. The mean duration of shots in a sequence, a measurable index of pace.

Subjective sound. Sound presented as heard by a character, such as muffled or distorted audio.

Your four-week plan

Week 1 - Vocabulary

Naming what you see.

- Log shots for ten minutes of any film.
- Describe five frames neutrally.
- Convert three adjectives into mechanisms.

Week 2 - Sequence

Pattern and pace.

- Measure average shot length in two sequences.
- Mark where the pattern breaks.
- Write 400 words on one break.

Week 3 - Sound

Listening.

- Watch a sequence image-off.
- Note diegetic and non-diegetic layers.
- Explain one sound bridge.

Week 4 - Essay

Argument.

- Choose one sequence and one claim.
- Write 800 words with timestamps.
- Cut every evaluative adjective.

Where to read more

Entry-level texts you can find in the university library or a departmental reading list. Confirm editions with your lecturer.

- Any introductory film analysis text covering mise-en-scene, editing and sound.
- A glossary of film terms to use consistently in your writing.
- One published analysis of a film from your region to see the method applied locally.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Distinguish continuity editing from montage.

Answer: Continuity editing preserves coherent space and time; montage builds meaning through the juxtaposition of shots that may not be spatially continuous.

2. What does a low camera angle usually suggest?

Answer: Power, dominance or threat in the subject, depending on context.

3. Why are timecodes essential in film analysis?

Answer: They let a reader verify your evidence and locate the exact moment you are discussing.

4. Give an example of non-diegetic sound.

Answer: A musical score that the characters cannot hear, added to shape the audience's emotional response.

5. What is mise-en-scene?

Answer: Everything placed within the frame: setting, props, costume, lighting and performance.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Watch a five-minute sequence three times and log every shot.
- [ ] Write a shot list with timecodes and descriptions.
- [ ] Analyse lighting direction in two scenes.
- [ ] Compare continuity editing and montage using two examples.
- [ ] Draft a 500-word sequence analysis with timecodes.
- [ ] Watch one Nollywood film and one African art film and compare form.
- [ ] Peer-review a coursemate's analysis for evidence, not opinion.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date:

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